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Beckham (pen)

‘What’s going on here? I can’t breathe.’

I wonder now: *Did that week in Dubai help finish me off as a United player in the eyes of the boss?*

I was out in the sunshine with England instead of being back at Carrington, clocking up the miles on the treadmill alone. I know the manager wasn’t best pleased about that. I had the feeling he wasn’t too happy, generally, about the extra responsibility—and the extra attention—that came with me captaining England. And he probably wasn’t keen, either, on the fact that Victoria and Brooklyn were in Dubai with me. It didn’t matter that I thought that marriage and fatherhood had settled me and had a positive effect on me as a player. The manager had always thought my family was a distraction from the serious business of soccer. He’d said as much to me often enough since I’d met Victoria. He thought my life at home got in the way: for me and for him.

I’d long since decided that it wasn’t an argument worth having. Was an argument ever worth having with the boss? I wasn’t going to convince him that being fulfilled as a person could only ever be good for me as a player. And, obviously, nothing he said was going to change how much I loved and cherished my family. It was great having Victoria and Brooklyn with me out in Dubai.

Sven thought it would be good if the players had their families around them. We were hoping to be away in Japan for the duration of the World Cup, after all. I remember talking to him about it before we left England, while he was planning our schedule. He believes in players having time with their partners and with their children. Most other countries see it that way. I